

China Industrials

Industrial insights (September): Industry performance continues to diverge

Equities

China

Industrial

Mixed picture of activity; how to position amid weak macro backdrop

We present key industrial data in our monthly China [Industrials Chartbook](#). Recent data remain mixed: domestic demand is weak, reflected in soft excavator and HDT sales and sluggish infrastructure investment, while factory automation orders, shipbuilding and industrial exports remain resilient. China industrials broadly tracked the CSI 300 over the past month, with shipbuilding, renewable equipment and defence outperforming, while construction machinery and HDTs lagged (Figure 3). Investor interest improved modestly on shipbuilding and mining equipment themes, though earnings visibility remains a key concern, especially in construction machinery and automation. Against multiple sector headwinds, we [prefer companies offering earnings visibility or structural growth with limited downside and attractive valuations](#), including **CSSC, CTI, Sany International, Hongfa, OPT, JDI, Sinotruk-H, Dingli and CRRC A/H**.

Weak infra FAI, excavators/HDT and strong shipbuilding orders continue

Despite faster special bond issuance since Q326, infrastructure FAI remained weak in August, down 14.3% YoY (versus -14.3% in July). Given the 4.8% decline in 8M26, we lower our 2026/2027 infrastructure FAI growth forecasts to -3.9%/+0.8% YoY, while expecting the contraction to moderate in September-October as bond issuance accelerates. Our channel checks indicate September domestic excavator sales were above 9,000 units, broadly flat YoY, although dealers suggest underlying demand has likely turned negative after adjusting for domestic-to-export transactions. We estimate September HDT shipments at 100k units, up 16% MoM and flat YoY, with domestic demand rising to 60k units and exports remaining stable at 40k units. Meanwhile, shipbuilding fundamentals remain solid, with the newbuild price index stable MoM in September and new orders up 18% YoY in August, bringing YTD growth to 111% YoY.

Factory automation and machine tool demand remain resilient

Our channel checks and expert discussions suggest automation order growth moderated in September but remained healthy, while machine tool orders continued to show solid momentum. China's industrial automation market remains in a structural recovery, with FA demand supported by AI-related supply chains and export-oriented equipment manufacturers, while PA demand is gradually stabilising. The expert expects the FA upcycle to extend to mid-2027. Industrial AI adoption remains in the pilot stage, with near-term automation demand primarily driven by data centre capacity expansion, while broader factory deployment is likely to progress gradually. Meanwhile, domestic automation vendors are accelerating overseas expansion, with Southeast Asia and Europe emerging as key growth markets.

Emerging themes: Humanoid developments and solid-state batteries updates

Humanoid robots: We recently raised our [2026-30 global robotics demand forecast](#) by over 70%, driven by faster adoption in preparatory and low-complexity applications. We see AI as a key enabler of broader robotics penetration and forecast 10-60% demand CAGRs for traditional robot categories through 2030. Within the value chain, we favour sensors, reducers and roller screws, which seem to offer attractive opportunities and high entry barriers, and are expected to account for 14%, 20% and 4%, respectively, of our estimated Rmb125bn robotics component TAM by 2030. **Solid-state batteries:** BYD reiterated its plan to launch its first [solid-state battery EV](#) in 2027. We see this as supportive for equipment vendors and BYD's supply chain, including Easpring. As the 2027 pilot rollout approaches, growing focus on solid-state batteries could provide upside for related supply-chain companies despite the lingering tech uncertainty.

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Figure 1: Valuation summary – our preferred stocks in China's industrial sector

Name	RIC Code	Market Cap (US\$ bn)	Rating	PT (LC)	Price (LC)	PE (x)		P/BV (x)		ROE (%)		Name	RIC Code	Market Cap (US\$ bn)	Rating	PT (LC)	Price (LC)	PE (x)		P/BV (x)		ROE (%)	
						2026E	2027E	2026E	2027E	2026E	2027E							2026E	2027E	2026E	2027E	2026E	2027E
CSSC	600150.SS	43.3	Buy	55.00	38.59	14.3x	10.9x	1.8x	1.6x	13.3	15.7	Sungrow	300274.SZ	26.8	Buy	144.00	86.83	13.7x	12.5x	3.1x	2.5x	25.2	22.4
Sinotruk-A	000951.SZ	3.5	Buy	31.00	20.26	11.0x	9.9x	1.4x	1.4x	13.6	14.2	CRRC-A	601766.SS	25.3	Buy	9.90	5.92	11.9x	10.7x	0.9x	0.9x	8.1	8.6
Sinotruk-H	3808.HK	12.8	Buy	56.00	36.24	10.4x	8.5x	1.7x	1.6x	17.7	19.4	CRRC-H	1766.HK	18.9	Buy	7.50	5.17	9.0x	8.0x	0.7x	0.7x	8.1	8.6
Hongfa	600885.SS	7.7	Buy	47.60	33.30	21.5x	18.3x	4.2x	3.6x	21.6	21.2	CTI	300012.SZ	3.7	Buy	20.50	14.85	22.3x	19.6x	2.9x	2.6x	13.8	14.1
JD Industrials	7618.HK	4.2	Buy	22.80	13.28	22.0x	14.7x	2.4x	2.1x	11.9	15.2	Sany International	0631.HK	3.4	Buy	10.80	8.19	11.1x	7.8x	1.6x	1.4x	15.2	19.5
OPT	688686.SS	2.6	Buy	176.00	141.79	68.6x	46.6x	5.4x	4.9x	8.1	11.1												

Source: Thomson Reuters, UBS-S estimates. Note: Data as of 23 Sep 2026.

Figure 2: Summary of key industrial-related numbers (YoY)

		2025 YoY										2026 YoY								2025 vs 2024
		Jan	Feb	Mar	Apr	Jul	Aug	Sept	Oct	Nov	Dec	Jan	Feb	Mar	Apr	May	Jun	Jul	Aug	
Manufacturing	Construction machinery																			
	Excavator sales (total)	1%	53%	18%	18%	25%	13%	25%	8%	14%	19%	50%	-11%	26%	30%	36%	35%	14%	19%	17%
	o/w: domestic	0%	99%	29%	16%	17%	15%	22%	2%	9%	11%	61%	-42%	23%	35%	39%	34%	4%	4%	18%
	o/w: export	2%	13%	3%	19%	32%	11%	29%	13%	19%	27%	40%	37%	32%	23%	34%	36%	21%	33%	16%
	Pangyuan index: proxy for rental rate	-7%	-19%	1%	-12%	-9%	-12%	-8%	-22%	0%	-1%	19%	12%	-11%	12%	2%	-5%	14%	3%	-9%
	Tower crane for fabricated building (ton meters)	-6%	-1%	-4%	-8%	-7%	0%	-8%	-4%	-3%	-1%	4%	7%	5%	3%	4%	3%	0%	-1%	-5%
	Loader sales (total)	2%	34%	13%	19%	-84%	0%	30%	28%	32%	30%	48%	9%	22%	32%	27%	25%	31%	15%	18%
	o/w: domestic	-1%	63%	23%	35%	2%	0%	26%	33%	29%	18%	43%	-14%	17%	17%	23%	16%	27%	14%	22%
	o/w: export	4%	13%	1%	0%	13%	0%	35%	23%	35%	41%	53%	34%	31%	57%	76%	33%	35%	16%	13%
	Crane sales (total)	-21%	0%	-17%	3%	10%	0%	22%	15%	17%	38%	29%	-12%	26%	10%	18%	19%	7%	8%	1%
	Heavy-duty truck																			
	HDT sales	-25%	36%	-4%	7%	46%	47%	83%	60%	65%	22%	46%	-10%	25%	33%	23%	19%	-1%	-6%	27%
	o/w: construction HDT	-28%	28%	5%	22%	68%	52%	71%	39%	47%	19%	38%	-2%	22%	15%	16%	15%	-1%	-4%	28%
	o/w: logistics HDT	-23%	45%	-11%	-6%	29%	42%	95%	83%	85%	25%	54%	-16%	27%	53%	31%	23%	-1%	-8%	26%
	Automation																			
	Industrial robot production	NA	NA	22%	42%	40%	33%	41%	14%	31%	26%	NA	NA	49%	30%	46%	48%	55%	51%	32%
	Lithium battery installed capacity	20%	92%	62%	53%	35%	33%	39%	42%	39%	30%	8%	-24%	0%	15%	26%	31%	33%	26%	40%
	Solar cells production	NA	NA	42%	56%	44%	55%	11%	2%	8%	11%	NA	NA	-9%	-10%	-6%	10%	-1%	-4%	28%
	Shipbuilding																			
	New order (in dwt)	-45%	-43%	-72%	-31%	31%	-49%	4%	2%	76%	100%	78%	171%	125%	48%	140%	13%	-28%	18%	-19%
	Delivery (in dwt)	-13%	-45%	21%	-7%	15%	7%	72%	14%	51%	15%	26%	26%	19%	7%	-2%	10%	15%	-6%	9%
	Container																			
	Production	51%	NA	23%	-9%	-17%	-25%	-29%	-52%	-42%	-35%	-14%	-14%	-14%	-14%	-14%	-14%	-14%	-14%	-21%
	Export volume	45%	-6%	30%	24%	0%	-45%	-30%	-18%	-12%	-12%	-19%	-17%	-34%	-20%	-33%	0%	2%	41%	-16%
Infrastructure	Infra FAI																			
	Infrastructure FAI (incl. utilities)	10%	10%	13%	10%	-1%	-3%	-4%	-8%	-9%	-10%	NA	11%	7%	-3%	-10%	-11%	-15%	-14%	1%
	Infrastructure FAI (excl. utilities)	6%	6%	6%	6%	-5%	-6%	-5%	-9%	-10%	-12%	NA	11%	7%	-3%	-10%	-11%	-12%	-13%	-2%
	o/w: Transport	3%	3%	5%	4%	-4%	-5%	-5%	-10%	-2%	-13%	NA	9%	22%	2%	-6%	-8%	2%	-1%	1%
	o/w: Hydraulic, environmental and public facilities	9%	9%	11%	6%	-7%	-15%	-15%	-19%	-25%	-27%	NA	8%	0%	-8%	-14%	-13%	-27%	-26%	-8%
	o/w: Utilities	25%	25%	26%	24%	13%	4%	-2%	-6%	-4%	-4%	NA	13%	7%	-5%	-12%	-9%	-25%	-17%	9%
	Railway FAI (MoT)	7%	7%	5%	NA	6%	6%	7%	5%	7%	6%	NA	5%	5%	-1%	1%	1%	0%	0%	6%
	Highway FAI (MoT)	86%	86%	-10%	-9%	-3%	0%	1%	-6%	-5%	NA	NA	NA	NA	-16%	NA	-11%	NA	NA	-6%
	Power grid FAI (CES)	33%	33%	18%	107%	-1%	26%	-11%	-14%	-1%	NA	NA	NA	NA	NA	NA	NA	NA	NA	NA
	Construction new contract																			
	CSCEC new contract	4%	6%	13%	20%	9%	-3%	1%	5%	2%	0%	2%	2%	-4%	2%	-11%	0%	NA	NA	2%
	Housing	-16%	11%	-1%	-13%	30%	8%	4%	11%	19%	-23%	16%	2%	2%	9%	-17%	7%	NA	NA	1%
	Infrastructure	74%	-5%	53%	-21%	-35%	-28%	-4%	-4%	-21%	35%	-23%	2%	-15%	-8%	3%	-12%	NA	NA	4%
	PowerChina new contract	2%	17%	-30%	16%	-13%	10%	8%	-39%	-26%	-36%	-15%	-33%	60%	-40%	-49%	-4%	-58%	-58%	5%
	MCC new contract	-13%	-43%	-27%	-17%	-13%	-15%	34%	28%	25%	-22%	-16%	9%	-17%	-46%	-35%	-28%	-46%	-54%	-11%

Source: Company data, National Bureau of Statistics (NBS), National Development and Reform Commission (NDRC), Ministry of Transport (MoT), China Aviation Administration of China (CAAC), China Port Association, National Energy Administration (NEA), China Construction Machinery Association (CCMA), China Association of Automobile Manufacturers (CAAM). Note: Airline data are an aggregation of Air China, China Southern, China Eastern and Spring Airlines. Airport pax throughput is an aggregation of Baiyun, Shanghai, Xiamen, Shenzhen and Beijing Capital international airports. Airport freight throughput is an aggregation of Baiyun, Shanghai, Xiamen and Shenzhen. Aircraft movement is an aggregation of Baiyun, Shanghai and Xiamen. Taiwan's shipping revenue includes revenue from Evergreen, Yang Ming and Wanhai. CES = China's energy storage. Green means above historical average; red means below historical average

Figure 3: UBS-S coverage universe – industrial stocks

Ticker	EN	Lead	Rating	MarketCap (Rmb bn)	TP	LC	Upside	1wk	1mth	3mth	YTD	Last update
000300.SH	CSI300						4,517.3	1.51	-2.20	-8.61	-2.88	
Construction machinery												
600031.SH	Sany Heavy Industry	Phyllis Wang	Buy	161.0	23.2	17.5	32%	-10.16	-6.86	0.33	-15.98	2026-03-31
601100.SH	Jiangsu Hengli Hydraulic	Phyllis Wang	Buy	122.8	128	91.6	40%	-7.30	-13.41	-16.27	-18.49	2026-04-22
000425.SZ	XCMG Construction Machinery	Phyllis Wang	Buy	84.9	12.6	7.2	74%	-7.43	-9.74	-11.09	-34.63	2026-04-30
000157.SZ	Zoomlion Heavy Industry Science & Tech A	Phyllis Wang	Neutral	52.8	8.7	6.1	43%	-5.57	-12.36	-13.79	-24.93	2026-04-01
1157.HK	Zoomlion Heavy Industry Science & Tech H	Phyllis Wang	Neutral	41.3	8.95	5.6	60%	-4.28	-21.54	-23.25	-23.95	2026-04-01
603338.SH	Zhejiang Dingli Machinery	Yuhua Li	Buy	27.5	70.9	54.3	31%	-3.76	0.97	24.14	-2.48	2026-09-04
0631.HK	Sany Heavy Equipment International	Yuhua Li	Buy	22.6	10.8	8.2	32%	-12.55	1.17	18.70	-1.34	2026-08-31
000528.SZ	Guangxi Liugong Machinery	Yuhua Li	Buy	15.4	12.5	7.6	64%	-7.08	-5.47	-1.68	-33.93	2026-08-31
3339.HK	Lonking	Yuhua Li	Neutral	11.6	3.65	3.2	15%	-4.79	-1.55	19.10	14.56	2026-08-28
Sector average								-6.99	-7.64	-0.42	-15.69	
Automation												
688836.SH	Yushu Technology	Phyllis Wang	Neutral (CBE)	198.6	608	491.0	24%	4.51	-26.98	-41.90	-41.90	2026-08-28
300124.SZ	Shenzhen Inovance Technology	Phyllis Wang	Buy	142.7	86	52.7	63%	2.27	-10.69	-20.49	-30.61	2026-04-29
688777.SZ	Zhejiang Supcon Technology	Phyllis Wang	Neutral	63.9	74.8	81.3	8%	-4.38	-10.78	-33.09	66.94	2026-03-16
688017.SH	Leader Harmonious Drive Systems	Phyllis Wang	Sell	52.6	216	286.9	25%	2.68	-8.73	-25.09	50.21	2026-09-21
002747.SZ	Estun Automation	Phyllis Wang	Neutral	28.5	22.4	29.5	24%	2.93	-12.21	-21.66	24.56	2026-04-16
002444.SZ	Hangzhou Great Star Industrial	Phyllis Wang	Buy	33.4	43	28.0	54%	-1.20	-4.79	-3.78	-14.89	2026-04-29
7618.HK	JD Industrials	Phyllis Wang	Buy	28.5	22.8	13.3	72%	-2.92	0.08	19.00	-5.82	2026-03-09
301029.SZ	Dongguan Yiheda Automation	Phyllis Wang	Neutral	15.8	27.4	25.0	10%	4.26	1.76	-13.86	-4.87	2026-08-31
688686.SH	OPT Machine Vision	Phyllis Wang	Buy	17.3	176	141.8	24%	0.83	15.43	-7.51	13.24	2026-08-21
601882.SH	Ningbo Haitian Precision Machinery	Phyllis Wang	Buy	12.5	24.3	23.9	2%	9.77	19.05	21.16	24.33	2026-03-24
688697.SH	Neway CNC Equipment	Phyllis Wang	Buy	9.8	13.7	15.3	10%	8.07	4.37	9.07	40.71	2026-04-28
603915.SH	Jiangsu Guomao Reducer	Phyllis Wang	Buy	8.7	20.6	13.2	56%	3.21	0.61	-13.29	-28.37	2026-01-13
Sector average								2.50	-2.74	-10.95	7.79	
Rolling Stock												
601766.SH	CRRCL Corp - A	Yuhua Li	Buy	169.9	9.9	5.9	67%	-1.82	-1.99	14.83	-11.82	2026-08-20
1766.HK	CRRCL Corp - H	Yuhua Li	Buy	126.9	7.5	5.2	45%	0.00	1.06	12.67	-9.05	2025-08-25
3898.HK	Zhuzhou CRRC	Yuhua Li	Buy	34.1	50.4	28.3	78%	-1.87	-14.21	-24.50	-21.77	2026-08-20
Sector average								-1.23	-5.05	1.00	-14.21	
Testing												
300012.SZ	Centre Testing International	Phyllis Wang	Buy	25.0	20.5	14.9	38%	0.81	-1.53	3.83	11.53	2026-08-19
300416.SZ	Suzhou Sushui Testing	Phyllis Wang	Buy	7.3	19.7	14.4	37%	3.22	-1.97	-28.56	-19.75	2026-03-27
603018.SH	China Design Group	Grace Wang	Neutral	4.3	6.25	5.2	20%	1.17	0.39	-2.54	-15.56	2026-04-21
Sector average								1.74	-1.04	-9.09	-7.93	
Battery equipment												
300450.SZ	Wuxi Lead Intelligent Equipment	Kunlun Li	Sell	54.3	36	32.4	11%	2.76	-4.42	-27.92	-35.75	2026-05-07
300457.SZ	Shenzhen Yinghe Technology	Kunlun Li	Sell	13.8	18.4	21.3	13%	1.53	6.52	-3.03	-22.28	2026-04-02
Sector average								2.14	1.05	-15.47	-29.02	
PV equipment												
300316.SZ	Zhejiang Jingsheng M&E	Kunlun Li	Neutral	55.4	44.3	42.3	5%	7.74	-0.54	-25.87	12.98	2026-04-15
300751.SZ	Suzhou Maxwell	Kunlun Li	Neutral	56.2	216.3	201.3	7%	5.02	4.21	-11.39	5.25	2026-08-26
300724.SZ	Shenzhen SC New Energy	Kunlun Li	Neutral	19.2	61.8	55.2	12%	8.32	-4.33	-20.25	-42.15	2026-08-31
002158.SZ	Shanghai Hanbell Precise Machinery	Phyllis Wang	Buy	15.1	31.1	28.3	10%	10.60	7.32	-19.20	14.20	2026-04-27
300820.SZ	Sichuan Injet Electric Co., Ltd.	Phyllis Wang	Buy	16.3	60	73.7	19%	22.81	39.73	-6.77	54.07	2026-04-30
Sector average								10.90	9.28	-16.70	8.87	
Diversified Industrials												
002851.SZ	Shenzhen Megmeet Electrical	Kunlun Li	Neutral	71.5	124.8	122.9	2%	3.47	-4.07	-27.85	37.66	2026-04-29
600885.SH	Hongfa Technology	Kunlun Li	Buy	51.5	47.6	33.3	43%	-4.12	-5.24	-2.06	9.93	2026-07-30
002050.SZ	Zhejiang Sanhua Intelligent Controls	Nora Min	Buy	151.4	58	36.0	61%	6.48	-1.96	-17.47	-30.84	2026-08-27
301377.SZ	Guangdong Dtech Technology	Yuhua Li	Buy	166.4	506	392.4	29%	-2.50	-5.80	-36.72	172.31	2026-09-14
603308.SH	Anhui Yingliu Electromechanical	Ken Liu	Neutral	27.3	44	40.2	10%	-3.18	-9.33	-39.42	-6.72	2026-09-21
605060.SH	Allied Machinery	Sky Hong	Buy	9.8	58	40.4	43%	5.95	-5.36	-19.02	10.63	2026-08-06
Sector average								1.02	-5.29	-23.75	32.16	
Defence												
688297.SH	Avic (Chengdu) Uas	Xin Chen	Neutral	29.0	50.32	43.0	17%	1.18	10.90	-3.54	-8.97	2025-09-09
300699.SZ	Weihai Guangwei Composites	Kunlun Li	Neutral	19.5	36	23.6	53%	0.90	-3.40	-17.04	-39.01	2026-04-24
2357.HK	AviChina Industry & Technology	Xin Chen	Buy	20.3	5	3.0	68%	6.42	0.84	4.01	-22.22	2025-09-05
Sector average								2.83	2.78	-5.53	-23.40	
Shipbuilding												
000039.SZ	China International Marine Containers A	Robin Xu	Buy	47.4	13.1	8.8	49%	-3.30	-5.89	2.25	-10.68	2026-08-31
600150.SH	China CSSC Holdings	Kunlun Li	Buy	290.4	55	38.6	43%	1.13	14.58	10.39	17.33	2026-09-04
YAZG.SI	Yanzhijiang Shipbuilding	Kunlun Li	Buy	108.3	5.4	5.3	3%	3.34	10.50	49.01	59.86	2026-08-10
Sector average								0.39	6.40	20.55	22.17	
HDT												
3808.HK	Sinotruk (Hong Kong)	Wei Shen	Buy	85.6	56	36.2	95%	-11.31	-4.80	-3.37	38.10	2026-08-27
000951.SZ	Sinotruk Jinan Truck	Wei Shen	Buy	23.8	31	20.3	99%	-4.66	-4.30	2.66	25.45	2026-08-27
000338.SZ	Weichai Power - A	Wei Shen	Neutral	225.6	28.5	25.9	10%	-0.58	-11.21	-11.76	50.92	2026-08-28
2338.HK	Weichai Power	Wei Shen	Neutral	224.1	33.7	30.1	12%	-0.99	-9.99	-19.38	60.64	2026-08-28
Sector average								-4.38	-7.58	-7.96	43.78	
All average								0.51	-2.12	-8.06	4.73	

Source: Wind, UBS-S estimates. Note: Data as of 23 Sep 2026.

Industry channel/expert checks

China HDT Sector: "Trade-in subsidies implemented in September"

September is the typical peak season for heavy-duty trucks (HDTs). Dealers in multiple regions noted that domestic demand picked up notably from August due to the implementation of trade-in subsidies for China IV vehicles. Downstream applications mainly include coal transportation, express delivery and logistics, and inter-factory cargo transportation. Gas prices remained elevated MTD, while diesel prices also rebounded from early July to the April-May levels. As a result, more HDT users shifted to e-HDTs, with penetration likely to reach a record high. We estimate HDT shipments at 100k units in September, up 16% MoM and broadly on a par with the high base of last September. Breaking this down, domestic demand is likely to rise 30% MoM to 60k units, while export volume could be flattish MoM at 40k units.

We estimate HDT shipments at 100k units in September, up 16% MoM and broadly on a par with the high base of last September.

Domestic excavator demand remained soft in September despite broadly stable sales

Our channel checks suggest September domestic excavator sales reached slightly above 9,000 units, broadly flat versus 9,249 units in September 2025. However, dealers generally believe headline sales data continue to be distorted by domestic-sales-to-export transactions, and underlying end-market demand has likely already turned negative after excluding this factor. Sales conversion, project starts and repayment conditions all remained weak, suggesting that the recovery in actual construction activity may still be limited.

Dealer feedback was notably more cautious than OEM commentary. While manufacturers attributed September softness to seasonal factors and holiday-related delivery disruptions, most channel participants described demand as weaker than expected across infrastructure and construction-related sectors. They did not observe any meaningful price increases in either domestic or overseas markets, indicating that weaker sales were driven by soft demand rather than pricing pressure. At the same time, repayment conditions showed little improvement despite fiscal stimulus, reflecting the lag between special bond issuance and actual project execution.

Looking ahead, they expect domestic demand to remain subdued in the near term, although accelerated policy support since late August could support a modest recovery in November-December. Overall, they continue to expect only low-single-digit domestic growth in Q426, with the current cycle remaining primarily replacement-driven rather than investment-led.

Key takeaways from automation expert call

On 21 September we invited an expert from Gongkong to share his insights on the FA industry outlook ([replay](#)). We summarise the expert's views below.

1) Demand: FA leads recovery while PA nears trough

FA continues to outperform PA. China's industrial automation market grew c.4% YoY in H126, with a clear divergence between FA and PA. FA increased c.10% YoY, while PA declined 1-2%. Incremental demand was primarily driven by AI-related supply chains and export-oriented manufacturing. OEM equipment demand growth is expected to moderate in H226 due to tougher comps and inventory normalisation, while weakness in project-based industries should continue to ease. Looking at 2027, project-related demand is expected to be flat to slightly positive, while OEM demand should maintain modest growth, resulting in less pronounced market polarisation. Industry expert expects the FA upcycle to remain intact through at least mid-2027.

Growth outlook remains constructive. Experts forecast FA growth of 6-8% in H226, implying full-year growth of 8-9%, followed by c.5-6% growth in 2027. In contrast, PA is expected to post a slight decline in 2026 before stabilising at flat to marginally positive growth next year.

AI and export demand are the key growth drivers to support FA. More than one-third of incremental demand is estimated to come from AI and AI-related supply chains.

Another one-third is estimated to be driven by export-oriented manufacturing and domestic upgrade and replacement demand. The remainder is estimated to be attributable to pricing increases and inventory replenishment.

End-market performance remains highly differentiated. Strong-performing sectors include electronics manufacturing, semiconductors, lithium batteries and energy storage, machine tools, textile machinery, data centres, and liquid-cooling equipment, with growth rates generally around 10%. In contrast, process industries remain weak, particularly petrochemicals, cement and metals. The petrochemical and chemical sectors are down approximately 6-7% YoY.

Product trends seem to favour discrete automation. PLCs' demand grew c.10% YoY, industrial robots by more than 10%, general-purpose servo systems by over 20% and CNC systems by nearly 20%, while high-end sensors also recorded double-digit growth. By contrast, low-voltage inverters, DCS (Distributed Control System) and instrumentation products' demand declined by 3-10%, reflecting continued weakness in process automation markets.

2) Industrial AI: Industrial companies have moved from awareness of AI to initial experimentation, with their primary objectives ranked as cost reduction, quality improvement and labour efficiency, according to the expert. Relatively clear use cases include predictive maintenance, energy conservation, production management, quality inspection, intelligent robotic picking, warehousing and production-line upgrades. In the near term, AI-related automation demand is still mainly driven by capacity expansion in data centres and supporting industries such as chips, optical modules and PCBs, rather than large-scale deployment on the production floor, according to the expert. Adoption in manufacturing is likely constrained by limited integration between platforms and equipment, insufficient intelligence at the edge layer, data silos and security concerns, weak user capabilities and long payback periods. Traditional automation hardware still accounts for 80-90% of installed industrial equipment. Over the next one to two years, the adoption of intelligent edge-layer hardware, including PLCs, sensors and variable-frequency drives, will be a key area to monitor. Industrial AI is therefore more likely to penetrate gradually than experience a near-term surge, according to the expert.

3) Overseas expansion: The globalisation of China's automation industry is expanding beyond traditional EPC projects and OEM equipment supply to include equipment for overseas data centres, direct exports by China's brands, and supply-chain exports supported by a recovery in overseas industries, with Southeast Asia and Europe showing particularly strong momentum. Overseas recognition of China's brands is improving, but exports remain concentrated in low- to mid-end products such as industrial power supplies, variable-frequency drives and small PLCs, while mid- to high-end PLCs and servo systems still account for a limited share. The move towards higher-end equipment exports – growing by more than 20% overall and by 30-40% in some segments – currently benefits foreign brands such as ABB, Siemens more directly. Looking ahead, foreign suppliers may leverage products localised in China to expand into Southeast Asia, shifting overseas competition from a straightforward story of China's brands going global to a multi-layered contest centred on localised manufacturing, cost-performance and channel service, according to the expert.

Valuation Method and Risk Statement

Investment downsizing at the macroeconomic level remains a key risk for China's industrial sector. If China's economy remains weak, demand for industrial goods or import/export volume could shrink, resulting in slow growth. If preferential policies, such as tax incentives for high-tech companies, are cancelled it could affect earnings. Intense competition with domestic or foreign enterprises could cause market share losses.

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Sell	FSR is > 6% below the MRA.	6%	21%

Source: UBS. Rating allocations are as of 30 June 2026.

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Company Name	Reuters	12-month rating	Price	Price date
CRRC Corp - A ¹⁸	601766.SS	Buy	Rmb5.92	23 Sep 2026
CRRC Corp - H ¹⁸	1766.HK	Buy	HK\$5.17	23 Sep 2026
Centre Testing International	300012.SZ	Buy	Rmb14.85	23 Sep 2026
China CSSC Holdings	600150.SS	Buy	Rmb38.59	23 Sep 2026
Hongfa Technology ¹³	600885.SS	Buy	Rmb33.30	23 Sep 2026
JD Industrials ^{2,4,6,28}	7618.HK	Buy	HK\$13.28	23 Sep 2026
OPT Machine Vision	688686.SS	Buy	Rmb141.79	23 Sep 2026
Sany Heavy Equipment International ²⁸	0631.HK	Buy	HK\$8.19	23 Sep 2026
Sinotruk (Hong Kong)	3808.HK	Buy	HK\$36.24	23 Sep 2026
Sinotruk Jinan Truck	000951.SZ	Buy	Rmb20.26	23 Sep 2026
Sungrow Power Supply	300274.SZ	Buy	Rmb86.83	23 Sep 2026
Zhejiang Dingli Machinery	603338.SS	Buy	Rmb54.28	23 Sep 2026

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